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Mughal twilight: The emergence of regional states and the East India Company

Our time traveller in 1707, especially if he had been misled by European accounts of ‘Oriental despots’, may well have failed to appreciate the extent to which the Mughal Empire, like other pre-modern political systems of that scale, operated by a hierarchic distribution of authority among different levels of society. There was no monopoly of military force; there was no monopoly of political authority. The Mughal himself was *shahinshah*, ‘king of kings’, hence one sovereign among many. Competition to expand geographically was always endemic, as was competition between the vertical levels of the system. It is conflict, as Bernard Cohn has written using the late Mughal period as an example of such systems, that achieves the precarious consensus and balance that allows such political systems to persist. Effective rule required not only resolving competition but also judgment about the conflicts with which to engage. During the first half of the eighteenth century Mughal power contracted, while those who had once been subordinate to the Mughals flourished. Among the new regional powers was a joint stock company of English traders, which, by century’s end, was poised to claim the mantle of the Mughals as ruler of the subcontinent.

THE ‘FAULT LINES’ OF MUGHAL CONTROL

A cogent perspective on Aurangzeb as ruler comes from one Bhimsen, a Hindu Kayastha memoirist, who, in his final decades of service, acted as auditor and inspector for a Rajput noble. Writing at

the end of Aurangzeb's life, Bhimsen gives us a 'grass roots' view of what he sees as imperial failure. He was, as John Richards has written, one of many who claimed generations of loyalty to the Mughal regime, men who prided themselves on their devotion and courage as well as their mastery of Indo-Persian courtly culture. As Bhimsen followed his master into the futile battles against the rebellious zamindars and chiefs, he despaired of the difference between earlier Mughal rule and that of the later Aurangzeb:

When the aim of the ruling sovereign is the happiness of the people, the country prospers, the peasants are at ease, and people live in peace. The fear of the king's order seizes the hearts of high and low. Now that the last age [kaliyuga] has come, nobody has an honest desire; the Emperor, seized with a passion for capturing forts, has given up attending to the happiness of the subjects. The nobles have turned aside from giving good counsel.

Bhimsen then went on to make what one might call a sociological point about the disorder he deplored. The zamindars, he explained, had 'assumed strength...enlisted armies, and laid the hand of oppression on the country'.

In identifying the upstart zamindars as a key sign of disorder, Bhimsen singled out one of the three crucial 'fault lines' that opened up challenges to centralized Mughal rule. The zamindars were men with local roots, often lineage heads and chieftains, who possessed local knowledge, and control over peasant cultivators. They had amassed power as they grew in wealth during the prosperous seventeenth century, and they had secured recognition, sometimes even including rank and office, from the Mughal authorities. After Aurangzeb's death, as Muzaffar Alam has made clear in several studies, zamindars across northern and central India rose up to resist imperial authority. Rarely did they coordinate their activities. Indeed to the contrary, local chieftains often contested with each other for mastery of the countryside. Some did, however, come together to form cohesive communities able to sustain an enduring challenge to Mughal authority. Among these, the most prominent were the Marathas of the Deccan, the Sikhs in the Punjab, and the Jats south-east of Delhi in the area of Agra.

A second 'fault line' intrinsic to Mughal administration was that of established princely rulers, who had accepted Mughal power but

kept authority within their own compact domains, rendering tribute but not subject to Mughal administration. Such territories were typically located in inaccessible or peripheral areas. Some chiefs simply ceased to deliver tribute; some, increasingly, resisted Mughal demands from the strength of their forts. To some extent the Rajputs, who had held full control of their desert homeland even while serving the empire, fit this category. By the late seventeenth century, two of the most important Rajput houses were in rebellion.

The third 'fault line' was that of provincial governors, who were appointed by the emperor in the normal course as administrators over areas where they had no pre-existing local connections, but who then acted autonomously, even while continuing to pay lip service to Mughal authority. This style of breaking away became visible in 1724, when the imperial prime minister, Nizamu'l Mulk, withdrew to Hyderabad, ceased to participate in imperial projects, and even fought against Mughal troops to assert his autonomy. Harsh reality was soon dignified by ceremony, as he was made Mughal viceroy for the southern portion of the empire. The rich provinces of Awadh and Bengal similarly gained *de facto* independence beginning in the 1720s as the local governors, now called *nawabs*, appointed their own officials, and named their own successors (even if through the 1730s the successor would be confirmed by the emperor). As rulers of quasi-independent states, they diverted to themselves revenues formerly sent to Delhi, engaged in diplomatic and military activity, and withdrew from attendance at court. From appointed Mughal officials, these erstwhile governors had become by mid-century the heads of dynasties of their own.

In addition to these noble and chiefly rebels, the weakening of the empire opened opportunities for the ruthless and ambitious of all sorts. One, who later became a Robin Hood-like folk hero, was Papadu, a low caste Telegu bandit chieftain. In the years after 1700, as John Richards and V. Narayana Rao tell us his story, Papadu, from a toddy tapping (fermented liquor manufacturing) caste, recruited followers from an array of untouchable and ritually low groups to form an army of several thousand. With it he mounted successful assaults against several of the major towns in Telengana. Finally, following a year-long siege of his hill-fort refuge by a combined Mughal and zamindari force, Papadu was captured and killed.

Rebellion of this sort, as Richards and Narayana Rao make clear, was not destined for success. As leader of a 'dual rebellion', against both imperial and local chiefly authority, Papadu struck too boldly at the most basic ordering of society, and thus mobilized against him all those with a stake in the established hierarchies of caste and wealth.

These Mughal 'fault lines', especially that of the chiefs and zamindars, have often been viewed as an assertion of the Hindu struggle against alien rule. In the case of the Marathas, Indian nationalists of the later nineteenth century, like the moderate M. G. Ranade, saw Shivaji and his successors through the anachronistic lens of an emerging resistance to British rule and so made them a 'nation' challenging 'foreign' domination. B. G. Tilak, the extremist nationalist, subsequently made of Shivaji a hero of Hindu rule. This theme took on new salience in the 1930s and 1940s as relations between Hindus and Muslims deteriorated in the years leading up to independence, so that Shivaji became a symbol of Hindu resistance to Muslim dominance. Similarly, Sikh resistance to Mughal rule has been interpreted as ideologically motivated. In fact, those in rebellion made alliances on the basis of expediency and did not seek out a religiously unified front. For example, when the Rajput Rajas of Marwar and Mewar rose during Aurangzeb's reign, Prince Akbar, sent to subdue them, instead joined them; he also allied with Shivaji's son and successor, before ultimately failing and fleeing for his life. The Marathas were active players in Mughal factional rivalries, paying lip service throughout to Mughal power, often striking deals to share access to contested tracts. Shahu (r. 1708–49), raised at court after his father, Shivaji's son Shambaji, was executed in 1689, accepted the position of Mughal *diwan* (the chief civil administrator) for the core Maratha areas. Certainly, distinctive rituals and ideologies were important to the insurgent regimes, but these did not preclude strategic cooperation and even alliances with Muslim rulers.

THE NORTH-WEST: SIKHS, PERSIANS, AND AFGHANS

An agrarian-based Sikh revolt led by Banda Bahadur offered a major challenge to Aurangzeb's successor, the aged Bahadur Shah (r. 1707–12). The Sikhs, like the Marathas, are an example of the

formative role of interaction with Muslim dynasties over many centuries. Guru Nanak himself, the great teacher of loving devotion to a formless God and contempt for worldly structures of power and rank, was of a khatri family that served the Sultanate dynasties. He himself as a young man studied Persian and worked for some ten years in a revenue storehouse for the Afghan Lodi dynasty. Three of his successors were patronized by Akbar, during whose long reign Amritsar emerged as the centre of a virtually autonomous area. The gurus sought worldly as well as spiritual powers. Participation in factional competition for succession at the court in fact cost two gurus their lives. The last guru, Gobind Singh (1666–1708), like other Punjab chiefs, variously used and resisted Mughal rule. Although defeated by Aurangzeb at the end of his reign, Gobind appealed to the new emperor, in vain, for restoration of his lands. With Gobind's death, worldly leadership passed to guerilla chiefs, of whom the strongest was Banda.

Although the Mughals had the support of several Punjab zamindars and lineage heads, only in 1715 did they finally defeat and execute Banda. Many Sikhs then remained quiescent, but a core group took to the hills, plundering and killing. Even they responded, albeit briefly, to the overture of a Mughal jagir and a title to their leader in 1730. Held at bay by their own rivalries, their proximity to the imperial capital at Delhi, and invasions from the north-west in mid-century, the Sikhs were unable to do much more than raid and establish small principalities until the 1760s.

The Punjab, and with it Delhi, experienced devastating blows through every level of society in these decades. No episode more shattered imperial confidence and stability than the attack of the Persian Nadir Shah (r. 1736–47) in 1739, who wrought havoc along his routes and unleashed butchery and brutality that left some 30,000 dead in Delhi alone. His booty, as he returned home, included Shah Jahan's fabled peacock throne. Subsequent years saw a growth of Afghan power, profiting in part from Russian and Chinese expansion that drew Afghans into burgeoning networks of trade sustained in large part by Hindu bankers based in cities like Shikarpur. In 1748 and 1757 the Afghan Ahmad Shah Abdali (r. 1747–73), whose empire reached into Baluchistan, the Makran coast, Sind and much of the Punjab, attacked Delhi. The Delhi area was further challenged



Plate 2.1 Daulatabad Fortress, Maharashtra.

from within by the Afghan Rohillas and the Jat zamindars of Agra. The view from the perspective of Delhi, as indeed from much of the Punjab, would have been one of unmitigated chaos and confusion by the mid-eighteenth century.

**THE NEW REGIONAL ORDER: 'MILITARY FISCALISM'
AND CULTURAL EFFLORESCENCE**

The view from Delhi, nevertheless, does not describe India as a whole. Overall, the eighteenth century was a period of gradual population growth, slow rise in prices, urbanization, and the establishment of new markets. Within the zamindar warrior states, as well as within the now autonomous Mughal provinces, the new regional kingdoms were centres of effective state-building, reaching deeply into their populations and building powerful armies. The symbol *par excellence* of the eighteenth century was that of the fort. These comprised not only bastions like the rugged, highly defensible Deccan hill fort of Daulatabad (plate 2.1) asserting a regional power, but, within the regional states, the mud-walled strongholds of a range of local powers. But such fortified redoubts were not the whole story. By mid-century, the ruler of the new Jat kingdom centred at Bharatpur, in close proximity to the core of Mughal power, was sufficiently secure to build a garden palace in nearby Dig (Deeg). Although Raja Suraj Mal's Gopal Bhavan (plate 2.2) was named for Lord Krishna, to whom the rulers were devoted, his use of pietra dura work, along with domes, arches, and pavilions, and formal garden, all recall Mughal imperial style, and so provide a visual reminder of the extent to which those who challenged Mughal power were its products, at times even surpassing in effective administrative control their Mughal predecessors.

The Maratha state in the middle decades of the eighteenth century offers the best example of bureaucratic efficiency in this period. The key architects of this organization were a hereditary line of prime ministers, Chitpavan Brahmans, of whom the first was Balaji Vishvanath (r. 1713–20). Despite factional rivalries, Maratha military might, especially under the *peshwa*, or prime minister, Baji Rao (r. 1720–40), extended the state's reach into Gujarat and Malwa, with raids in the 1730s as far as Delhi, and to Bengal a decade later.



Plate 2.2 Gopal Bhavan, Garden Palace of the Jat rajas of Dig, c. 1763.

At the same time, the state established strong control over rural chiefs, military adventurers, and others who became the intermediaries to deliver the state's share of the revenue. In the Maratha domains as elsewhere, a prominent feature of the eighteenth century was the collapse at the local level of separate lines of civil and military authority, in favour of the single figure of the revenue *farmer* or contractor. The farmer bid to secure the right to pay into the state's treasury an agreed upon sum for a certain tract of land for a fixed term of years. He bore the expenses of collection, and he claimed as his own any additional revenues collected. For the state this arrangement provided a secure income at minimum cost. It often opened the way to extortion, however, as contractors, unchecked so long as they filled their contracts, set out to amass personal fortunes at the expense of hapless cultivators. Yet, where contracts were awarded for an extended series of years, revenue farmers had an obvious incentive to encourage agricultural prosperity in the areas under their control, and the process clearly gave many enterprising and upwardly mobile individuals an arena for action. The most successful farmers combined military power with cash advances to local villagers, as well as participation in the trade of the commodities produced. The forty years when Mian Almas Ali held districts yielding one-third the revenue of Awadh, for example, were looked back upon by the people in later years as a 'golden age'.

An innovation with far-reaching implications for the working of the new system of regional states was the recruitment of infantry forces, handling more efficient artillery and deployed with far greater discipline and effectiveness than the traditional mounted cavalry of the Mughals. The eighteenth-century states welcomed European adventurers to train these new units of professional soldiers, who, unlike peasants conscripted by noble overlords for limited periods, were now full-time mercenary troopers. Uniformed, they were trained to follow orders even under attack. By mid-century, Hyderabad had contingents of French-led fighters, but Germans, Dutch, and others found their way to the Indian courts as well. Plate 2.3 shows the tomb in Agra of John William Hessing (and his in-laws and descendants), who began his career in the employ of the Dutch East India Company in Ceylon, moved on to serve the Nizam

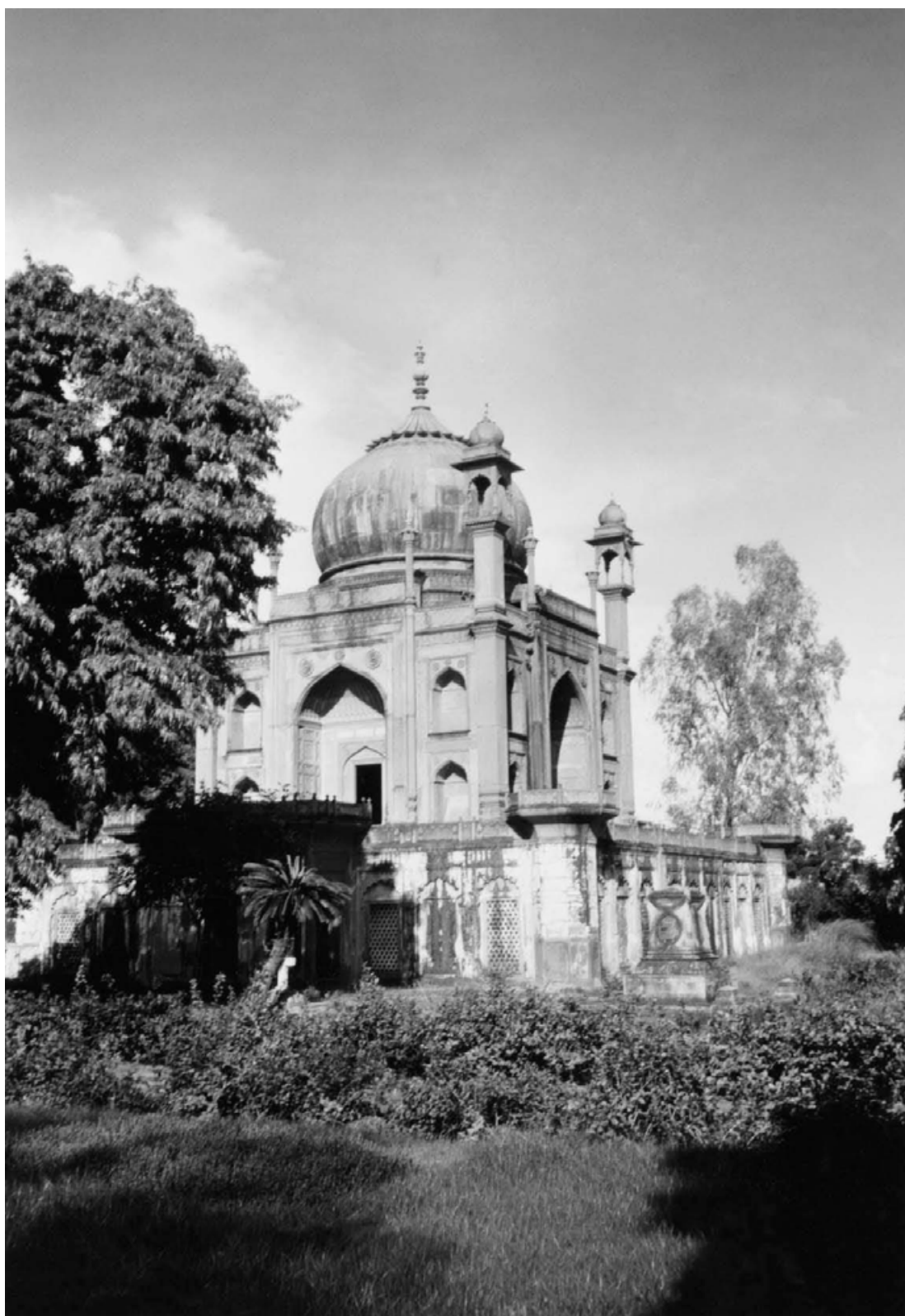


Plate 2.3 Mughal-style tomb of European ‘adventurer’ John William Hessing, Agra, 1803.

of Hyderabad, and ended as a colonel in the service of the Maratha Sindhia commanding the city of Agra. As the size and style of the tomb suggest, these men, while military adventurers, nevertheless adopted many Indian social and cultural practices.

Mercenary adventurers and infantry contingents were expensive, for they had to be paid in cash. This new demand on state resources stimulated novel strategies of governance. These strategies, summed up, in historian David Washbrook's phrase, as 'military fiscalism', created a new relationship between revenue extraction, the military, and financial agents. Building on the gradual monetization and economic expansion already evident in the previous century, rulers increasingly turned for assistance to families of bankers, traders, and revenue intermediaries. Over the years these men had established increasingly broad networks of clients and created financial instruments that enabled them to take up key roles in the political system. In Bengal, for instance, the banking family of the Jagat Seths provided credit to the nawabs, and advances for the selling and moving of crops to zamindars and revenue farmers. By mid-century such financiers had become indispensable to the rulers of many of India's states. At the same time, to facilitate revenue collection, zamindari landholdings were frequently consolidated, and, along with the older lineage heads and chiefs, new men, including court officials, military adventurers, and banking families themselves, emerged as zamindars.

As they grew ever more desperate for funds, some rulers adopted an opposite scheme, that of bypassing intermediaries and collecting directly from the peasantry. This was the solution adopted by the Muslim conquest state of Mysore, founded by Haider Ali in 1761. Haider and his son Tipu Sultan introduced into their state a rigorous revenue management founded upon the encouragement of peasant agriculture and the elimination of zamindars and farmers. In so doing they brought Mysore an enviable degree of prosperity, and the funds to maintain an army of 60,000 men. Yet no more than those who sought succour by borrowing could the Mysore rulers by their ruthless centralization of power stave off eventual defeat at the hands of those who, as we will see, controlled more resources and a larger army. In the end, 'military fiscalism' did not so much preserve India from conquest as open the way to it.

Recent studies of the Ottoman Empire in the eighteenth century suggest that society in that period underwent a limited transition from ‘vertical’ to ‘horizontal’ solidarities. One might imagine, schematically, a ‘vertical’ ordering of authority as one passing from the emperor to nobles to lesser functionaries to lineage heads, thence to village head and family patriarch. Problems would be solved hierarchically, by turning to the person above for a solution. In a ‘horizontal’ ordering, by contrast, solidarities among members of the same occupational group, or geographic region, or sectarian or other voluntary association, formed the basis for dispute settlement. The eighteenth-century move to a ‘civil society’ apart from the state may have been more evident in the Ottoman lands than in the Indian subcontinent. Nonetheless, a somewhat similar transition among such groups as traders, bankers, and networks of religious specialists, cutting across some boundaries of region and even ethnicity, was taking place in India as well.

The new regional states also fostered enduring changes in cultural expression, setting new directions in poetry, art, architecture, music, and religious thought. The Rajput courts in particular established themselves as centres of cultural patronage. [Plate 2.4](#) shows the palace dominating the remarkable new city of Jaipur, laid out by [Raja Jai Singh](#) in the 1720s and 1730s on a geometric grid. In the distance is the triangular shape of one of the astronomical devices of the Jaipur observatory, one of three Jai Singh established to measure celestial patterns. The eighteenth-century Rajput courts welcomed artists, including those fleeing the imperial capital, and, along with several states in the Himalyan hills, developed renowned schools of painting, each known for distinctive palettes, facial types, or subjects. Among the most significant subjects taken up were those known as *ragmala*, ‘a garland of musical modes’, which depicted visually the mood created by a classic musical mode, in this case those associated with episodes of the divine/human love represented above all by the symbol of Lord Krishna. [Plate 2.5](#) depicts the lovers Radha and Krishna as an approaching storm mirrors their mounting passion. The cult of Lord Ram, the ideal king, also flourished in this period. His legendary birthplace at Ayodhya emerged as a pilgrimage centre, its buildings patronized by the Shi‘a nawabs of Awadh. Warfare enhanced the popularity, also, of armed ascetic orders of



Plate 2.4 Jaipur city palace, with Jai Singh's astronomical observatory to the left rear.



Plate 2.5 Ragmala painting of Radha and Krishna, Kulu, early nineteenth century.

Gosains and Bhairagis, who were often looked to for protection in times of disorder.

Islamic traditions also found new expression in the regional settings. Poets like Shah Abdu'l Latif Bhita'i (1689–1752), writing in Sindhi, and Bulhe Shah (1680–1758) and Waris Shah (b. c. 1730), in Punjabi, produced masterpieces of mystic poetry in the vernaculars that reinterpreted local folk stories. Abdu'l Latif used the Kutchi

love story of Sasui searching for her Baluch beloved to tell the story of the human soul, symbolized as a woman, searching for the divine, much as in the bhakti poems and paintings of the era. This verse, for example, turns on the enduring theme of the poignancy of ‘love in separation’:

I have not met my love but thou
Art sinking to thy rest, O Sun.
The messages I give thee, take
And tell to my beloved one.
To Kech go, say: ‘The sad one died
Upon the path.’ ‘Twas not for me
To meet my love: death supervened.
I’ll die, be nothing utterly
In separation from my love.

At the Delhi court as well, the vernacular language of Urdu, with its heavy use of Persian loan words, was adapted to Persian poetic genres by great poets including Mir Taqi Mir (1723–1810) and Khwaja Mir Dard (1720–85).

One of the most influential figures in Muslim religious life in the capital was Shah Waliullah (1703–62), the Naqshbandi sufi, whom many later Islamic movements in modern India would claim as their forebear. He was part of the scholarly circles based in the Hijaz concerned with setting a new standard of fidelity to the traditions of the Prophet Muhammad’s sayings and actions (*hadith*). Those teachings found particular resonance in the renewed attention in eighteenth-century India to devotionism, across religious traditions, since in the Islamic case devotion to the Prophet was seen as essential in the quest for the divine. Hadith served also as an anchor in the flux of changing political and social circumstances of the period. In the Punjab and among the Rohillas in particular, Chishti sufis disseminated renewed attention to hadith. This was a period of Shi’a efflorescence as well. Shi’a-led states, including Bengal for a time, and, above all, Awadh, patronized the elaborate mourning ceremonies that expressed devotion to the Shi’a *imams*, and supported the writing and recitation of Urdu-language elegies (*marsiya*). This poetic tradition was begun by men like Mirza Rafi’ud-din Sauda (1713–81), who with so many others sought refuge at the Lucknow court from the mid-century disorder in Delhi.

In the wake of the collapse of authority in northern India, the climactic encounter in the struggle for mastery took place in 1761, as Marathas and Afghans marshalled their armies on the historic field of Panipat, where the Mughal Empire had been won. The battle defined the limits of power for both. The Afghans prevailed on the battlefield, but they were unable to sustain an empire so far from Afghanistan, and so withdrew. Maratha power, from its base in Poona had over the preceding decades extended its reach far to the north and east. Following the defeat at Panipat, further advance stopped and the Marathas split into four increasingly separate states. Each was dominated by one of the newly ascendant Maratha military houses, and each, although loosely linked to the peshwa in Poona, possessed its own geographic base: the Gaekwad in Baroda, Sindhia in Gwalior, Holkar in Indore, and the Bhonsle in Nagpur.

THE RISE OF THE ENGLISH EAST INDIA COMPANY

As a new system of regional states emerged, the English East India Company was amassing strength for what was to become a successful challenge to all of the others. Founded on 31 December 1600, and chartered by Queen Elizabeth, the English company was one among several European trading ventures that sought to tap the riches of the 'East'. Central to the enduring strength of the Company was its organization as a joint-stock enterprise. Individuals could not hope to trade on their own so far from Europe while the English Crown, unlike that of Portugal, did not care to commit its resources to so uncertain an undertaking. The joint-stock organization allowed merchants to share the risk of trade, and enabled them to raise further funds as needed. The access to resources provided by the company structure made the English a formidable competitor as they confronted India's indigenous merchant families. The Company gained further strength from its possession of centralized direction, through a 24-member Court of Directors, the stability of an archive, and a staff recruited for their specialized skills. As we shall see in subsequent chapters, it was in its engagement with India, not in England itself, that Britain developed many of the institutions of the 'modern' state, among which none was to be more crucial than the joint-stock corporation.

Granted a monopoly of Britain's Asian trade, and the right to arm its vessels in order to fend off interlopers, the Company sought entry into the hugely profitable spice trade with the islands of the East Indies. There, however, they encountered a better organized and financed rival, the Dutch East India Company (VOC). They quickly determined to centre their trading operations in India instead. This decision created both economic and political problems for the Company. Apart from Malabar pepper, which formed the bulk of the Company's earliest cargoes, India possessed no spices. To make matters worse, the Indians had no interest in the commodities England had available for sale, most notably woollen goods, so that, against the reigning principles of mercantilism, and to severe disapproval at home, the Company had to export bullion to pay for its Indian purchases. Furthermore, unlike the Dutch, who easily overwhelmed the petty rajas of the archipelago, the English in seventeenth-century India confronted the Mughal Empire at its height. Hence there could be no thought of conquest. Only as humble petitioners for favour could the English hope to gain access to the Indian market. The Mughals welcomed the English to offset the predominance of the Portuguese, and later of the Dutch, as did Indian merchants, who relished the opportunities afforded for profitable trade.

The East India Company during the seventeenth century, nevertheless, created for itself a secure and profitable trade. In place of the lucrative but limited trade in spices, the English developed markets in Europe for a variety of Indian produce, including indigo (a blue dye) and saltpetre (used for gunpowder). Most valuable, however, were fine quality hand-loomed Indian textiles. With the growth of a consumer economy in a prospering Britain, after 1660, the demand for Indian fabrics, such as chintz, calico, and muslin (all words of Indian origin), increased rapidly. As would be demonstrated time and again, the modern consumer possessed an almost insatiable desire for the luxury goods of the tropical, and subsequently colonial, world. The Company's imports from India to Europe, worth some £360,000 in 1670, tripled in value over the subsequent thirty years, and then doubled again to reach nearly 2 million pounds by 1740. The 1778 painting, *The East Offering its Riches to Britannia* (plate 2.6), depicts the array of Asian ports which supplied valuable



Plate 2.6 Painting of *The East Offering Its Riches to Britannia*, by Spiridion Roma, 1778, at the East India House, London.

goods, from tea to textiles, to Britain. Britannia, seated on a rock, is boldly superior, with her trade facilitated by the Greek god Mercury.

Sustaining this trade was a grant awarded in 1617 by the emperor Jahangir to Sir Thomas Roe, James I's ambassador to the Mughal court. Under its terms the English were allowed to establish factories at selected Mughal ports, most notably Surat in Gujarat. These 'factories' were not (in contradistinction to our current usage) sites of manufacture, but rather warehouses where goods were collected by resident agents, called factors, until they could be loaded aboard ship. Although the Company's naval prowess encouraged the Mughals to grant such trading rights, for the Mughals had no navy of their own, still the Company, not allowed to fortify its factories, remained wholly dependent on the goodwill of the Mughal authorities for their trading enterprise. These exports generated customs revenues, especially in Gujarat and later in Golconda, where in 1678 Dutch and English *specie* import met the paybill of 17,000 cavalymen; and they brought wealth to merchants and weavers. The historian Om Prakash has estimated that the overseas demand generated some 80,000 jobs, primarily in weaving, in Bengal alone. The major beneficiaries, however, were the local merchant entrepreneurs who gave out advances to weavers, and supplied commodities to the European companies. Until the coming of British supremacy, competition between rival European companies secured a reasonable return for Indian producers.

By the 1660s, as Mughal power began to falter, the Company found its factories, especially that in Surat, raided twice by Shivaji, increasingly vulnerable, and so turned to a policy of armed defence. This brought the Company into conflict with the Mughal authorities, who inflicted a humiliating defeat upon them in 1686. Nevertheless, by 1700 the Company had secured the three 'presidency' capitals – of Madras, Bombay, and Calcutta – from which its authority was subsequently to expand into the interior. Though only tiny footholds on the Indian coast, these three cities, secured by powerful fortifications, such as Fort St George, Madras, pictured in [plate 2.7](#), grew and prospered. Indian merchants flocked to them, seeking security for their persons and property in increasingly unsettled times. The English further sought to reassure Indians by disavowing any effort, of the sort practised by the Portuguese



Plate 2.7 Fort St George, Madras, c. 1750.

Inquisition and French Jesuits, at conversion to Christianity. Throughout the eighteenth century missionaries were refused residence in the English settlements.

Bombay, an island with a magnificent harbour, was secured in 1661, in a manner comparable to the alliances forged between Akbar and the Rajputs, as part of the dowry of a Portuguese princess who married King Charles II. As the Company shifted its operations there from Surat, Parsi merchants and artisans, Zoroastrians of Iranian origin, came along with them. For the most part the Company's officials lived a communal life within the forts, from where they dealt with the Indian brokers and merchants, settled outside, who procured textiles from weavers in the countryside by the provision of cash advances. These presidency capitals were not established with the objective of colonial conquest. The number of Company personnel posted to each never exceeded a few hundred, while the forts were guarded by ill-trained soldiers, some 300 in Madras, recruited from the streets of London.

The Indian trade participated in a larger worldwide trading arena. So-called 'Guinea' cloth, exported from India to West Africa, was used to purchase slaves for West Indian plantations, while in

South-east Asia Indian textiles provided the medium of exchange for the spice trade. Throughout the seventeenth century and the first decades of the eighteenth, the English had to contend with powerful rival trading companies, who, like themselves, established fortified posts along the coast of India. By the 1680s the long-established Dutch had been joined by the Danes and by the French at Pondicherry, a south Indian enclave they retained until 1950. As the Mughal Empire weakened following the death of Aurangzeb, and the trade grew ever more profitable, so too did the temptation to gain an advantage over one's rivals by political means. In 1717 the British secured from the emperor Farrukhsiyar the valuable boon of duty-free export of their goods from Bengal. The French, however, as late-comers had the most to gain from intervening in local politics.

The occasion was the War of the Austrian Succession in Europe (1744–8). This war inaugurated some seventy years of conflict between Britain and France, and with it a new kind of warfare in which these two European powers contended for mastery around the globe, in America and India as well as Europe itself. Increasingly, this rivalry was propelled by a modern nationalist enthusiasm which caught up peoples as well as dynasties. In India, the French governor-general François Dupleix (1697–1764) saw in the recurrent disputes over succession among Indian princes, among them Arcot and Hyderabad, an opportunity to advance French interests. He devised the strategy of offering one contender in such a dispute the support of French troops; in return, once in power, the client prince awarded the French favourable commercial terms at the expense of the British. At the same time, Dupleix moved directly against the British, successfully besieging Madras in 1746. These achievements moved the Pondicherry merchant Ananda Ranga Pillai to make of Dupleix an ideal Indian ruler:

When [the name of Pondicherry] is uttered, her enemies tremble, and dare not stir. All this is owing to the ability, readiness and luck of the present governor, M. Dupleix. His method of doing things is not known to anyone, because none else is possessed of the quick mind with which he is gifted. In patience he has no equal. He has peculiar skill in carrying out his plans and design... and in assuming a bearing at once dignified and courteous towards all.

In none of this was there any sense that Dupleix was a 'foreigner' whom an 'Indian' ought to oppose. Rather the French, like other Europeans, were simply assimilated into the shifting array of local powerholders.

This challenge to their interests provoked an immediate British response. They regained Madras by the 1749 treaty that ended the war, and they set out to turn the tables on Dupleix by playing the same game. In short order they had placed their client on the throne of Arcot, and Dupleix was soon recalled in disgrace. Despite Dupleix's insights into the precariously balanced eighteenth-century Indian political order, with the opportunities it afforded for manipulation, the French, preoccupied with dynastic quarrels in Europe, simply did not possess the resources to contain their rivals in India. Above all, as latecomers to India, they had never developed the close ties with Indian merchants and intermediaries that sustained the British, with the result that the French India trade, on average about half that of the English Company's in value, had by mid-century sunk to a mere quarter of that of their rival's. For Britain, by contrast, not only was the Company a major player in domestic politics, but popular opinion, especially in the country's port cities, saw in trade, and in empire, the way to secure Britain's greatness. 'Rule Britannia', a marker of the new patriotism, was first sung in 1740. The figure of Britannia, seated on a rock above her Asian tributaries in the Spiridion Roma painting (plate 2.6), visibly represents as well this growing sense of national identity, which set Britain apart from an Asia seen as a collection of cities and regions.

The four years of war from 1744 to 1748 made visible, for the first time to Europeans, the power of disciplined infantry in Indian warfare. A few hundred French or British soldiers, firing in volleys from a square formation, could now hold off thousands of Mughal cavalrymen. A contingent of European troops were thus worth a great deal to an Indian ruler. Critical too to European success was the fact of national loyalty. Although Europeans often took service as adventurers with Indian states, they would never fight against their own countrymen, or change sides in the middle of a battle, as Indians, motivated not by an equivalent 'Indian' nationalism but by more parochial loyalties, frequently did. The Seven Years' War, from 1756 to 1763, pitting Britain once again against

France, made apparent for all to see the implications of this ‘military revolution’.

THE CONQUEST OF BENGAL

From the early eighteenth century onwards, the trade of Bengal had grown ever more profitable to the East India Company. By 1750, this rich deltaic province, the outlet for the trade of the entire Ganges valley, accounted for 75 per cent of the Company’s procurement of Indian goods. Dean Mahomet, an Indian in Company employ who later emigrated to Britain, described Dacca (Dhaka), now the capital of Bangladesh, in these terms:

Dacca is considered the first manufactory in India and produces the richest embroideries in gold, silver, and silk...Provisions of all sorts are exceedingly cheap and plentiful in Dacca: the fertility of its soil, and the advantages of its situation have, long since, made it the centre of an extensive commerce... Here is also the residence of a grand Nabob, who, at his accession to the throne, conformable to an old custom, something similar to that of the Doge of Venice on the Adriatic, enjoys a day’s pleasure on the river, [in a barge] sheathed with silver.

Bengal’s wealth was thus at once made to appear nearly boundless, and made familiar by evoking Italy’s canal-laced ‘mistress of the seas’. It is not by accident that the figure representing Calcutta in *The East Offering its Riches* is placed at the centre of the painting with the richest gift, that of a basket of jewels and pearls. From such images came an enduring picture of India for the British.

Determined to extend their profits, the British in Bengal had by mid-century begun systematically abusing the right to free trade awarded them by the emperor. Free trade passes were sold to Indian favourites, and extended illegally to participation in the internal trade in grain and other commodities. In 1756, on the outbreak of war, to deter French attack, the British began extending the fortifications of Calcutta. All this the young Nawab Siraj-ud-daula, who had recently come to the throne of Bengal, rightly saw as a challenge to his authority. Hence in June 1756 he marched on Calcutta, defeated the garrison, and imprisoned those who were unable to flee. Some forty or more of those imprisoned, confined in a small airless room, died overnight of suffocation. Although the nawab

had not ordered this mistreatment of his English prisoners, which was an act of negligence on the part of his officers, nevertheless the incident, exaggerated as the 'Black Hole' of Calcutta, reverberated down the years as evidence for the British of Indian cruelty and barbarism.

To avenge this humiliation, the British turned to Colonel Robert Clive (1725–74), who had already distinguished himself in the wars in the south. An expedition mounted from Madras retook Calcutta in February 1757, and secured restoration of the Company's trading privileges. Not content with this victory, Clive entered into a conspiracy with a group of merchant bankers headed by Jagat Seth, at odds with the new nawab over his financial exactions from them, to overturn Siraj in favour of a more pliable ruler. Together they fixed upon the disaffected general Mir Jafar, who promised the British lavish payments in return for their help in placing him on the throne. The result was the famous battle of Plassey, on 23 June 1757. Militarily the battle was a farce, Mir Jafar's troops standing aloof as Clive routed Siraj's forces. The consequences of the encounter, however, were to be momentous.

Although Mir Jafar was made nawab after Plassey, he was, and was visibly seen to be, a puppet maintained in power by Clive and his army. The cash payments alone were staggering. The British received some 28 million rupees, equivalent to 3 million pounds sterling, of which nearly half went to private individuals, including Clive himself. The Company secured the revenue collecting rights over several districts, and an unimpeded trading access to the countryside. To be sure, Clive did not intend conquest, nor did the Company's directors at home. The Company's servants in India, determined to amass fortunes for themselves, refused any check on their rapacious activities. In the process, as they lived ever more extravagantly, they became known as nabobs, from the Mughal term nawab (governor). For its part, the Company too sought ever more funds for its trading operations. Significantly, after 1757 the Company ceased the shipment of bullion to Bengal. Instead, in a dramatic turn in Britain's economic relationship with India, it used the province's internal tax revenues to finance the purchase of the goods it annually shipped to England. Bengal was, Clive assured the governor of Madras, 'an inexhaustible fund of riches'.

Nawabi sovereignty was most visibly demeaned as the British took over for themselves the trade in a range of valuable commodities, notably salt, betel nut, tobacco, and saltpetre. These, as Sudipta Sen points out, were the 'Nawab's prestige goods' endowed with the signs of the ruler's authority. In 1760, the hapless Mir Jafar was replaced, following another round of presents, by Mir Kasim. Unwilling to countenance the continuing British plunder of his kingdom, Mir Kasim sought to retrieve his authority over at least the northern part of Bengal and adjacent Bihar. In so doing he provoked what was to be the final confrontation, for the British, their appetite for wealth and power whetted, would accept no constraints. By 1764 the battle lines were drawn, between Mir Kasim, allied with the Nawab of Awadh and the Mughal emperor on one side, and the East India Company on the other. On 23 October of that year, at Buxar, in a hard-fought contest unlike that of Plassey, the British made themselves the masters of eastern India.

No longer able to keep up the pretence that they were mere traders, in 1765, by a treaty with the Mughal emperor, in return for an annual tribute the Company secured the *diwani*, or revenue collecting rights, for the provinces of Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa. Legally, this made the Company the emperor's deputy, as revenue minister, a position they retained until 1858. The administration of justice, or *nizamat*, was left to the nawab. In form Bengal remained a Mughal province. In fact, however, it was wholly under the control of the East India Company, for neither the emperor in Delhi nor the figurehead nawab exercised any independent authority over the region. Still, however, the British vacillated. Reluctant to abandon a profitable trade for the uncertain advantages of rule, Clive as governor determined to leave the actual collection of the revenues in the hands of the nawab's officials. But mistrust of these officials, combined with the Company's insatiable need for funds, above all for its fast-growing army, led the British in 1772 to 'stand forth' as diwan. A new era was about to begin.

What, one must ask, impelled a 150-year-old trading company suddenly to embark on a career of conquest? And how were the British so easily able to carve out a state for themselves among the contending powers of post-Mughal India? As neither Clive nor the Company had devised a coherent plan, much was the product of

circumstance. The Seven Years' War provided a convenient occasion. Although France was not able after Dupleix to mount a serious challenge to Britain in India, still the war, with the patriotic sentiment it stirred up, justified military adventure around the globe. Clive's 'heroic' exploits in Bengal complemented, or so it seemed, those of James Wolfe in Quebec. Then there was simply the importance to the Company of the Bengal trade, together with, on the other side, the threat its size, and the privileged position of the British, posed to the nawab. Conflict, if not inevitable, depended on a restraint neither party was likely to exercise indefinitely. In addition, there was the sheer greed of the resident British. Once the opportunity to secure 'Nabob' wealth presented itself, there could be no holding back. Clive himself, after all, set the example. As he told the House of Commons in 1772, he was 'astonished at his own moderation' when he left India with an immense fortune, including the jagir of an Indian district worth £ 28,000 annually. The Company, for its part, initially hesitant, fearful of the spiralling costs of Clive's adventurism, became reconciled to empire once its fiscal advantages to themselves, above all in financing their Asian trade, became apparent. Indeed, the Company used its new-found wealth to construct a palatial headquarters for itself in London, for which it commissioned, as its centrepiece, the ceiling painting of the *East Offering its Riches* discussed above.

As it moved into Bengal, the Company took advantage of those strategies of 'military fiscalism' that were key to success in the political system of eighteenth-century India. Among these were a titular obeisance to the Mughal emperor in Delhi, utilization of trade monopolies in such goods as saltpetre that local nawabs had developed, the deployment of a disciplined professional infantry (which Europeans pioneered in India), and close ties with newly powerful banking and financial groups, such as the Jagat Seths, whose autonomous position gave them an unprecedented importance within the political system. More generally, one might argue, with David Washbrook, that the mid-eighteenth century witnessed a 'conjuncture' of two thriving commercial worlds, that of India and that of Western Europe. India and England, as part of the 'Early Modern' world, that is, had been simultaneously shaped by an interconnected trading system. Far from juxtaposing a 'progressive' Europe with a

declining 'traditional' India ripe for conquest, such an argument finds the key to the European penetration of India precisely in its accessibility and its flourishing economy.

But why did the English East India Company succeed so spectacularly in India when others, European and Indian, did not? Much of the answer lies in Europe. An island nation for whom overseas trade was vital, Britain was committed to securing its Indian interests at all costs. Control of the seas, in an era in which export trade brought the greatest profit, gave Britain an edge over all rivals. Note the 'East Indiaman' in Roma's painting (plate 2.6) above. For India, the eighteenth century thus offers a dramatic contrast with the Mughal agrarian order of the seventeenth, when overseas commerce was of secondary importance. Furthermore, although the industrial revolution was not yet underway, the British economy had already become suffused with a dynamic commercial ethos sustained by secure private property rights. In India the British could hold out to indigenous mercantile classes, first in the presidency capitals and then in the countryside, as local rulers did not, the attractive prospect of freedom from arbitrary exaction. Part of the reason for Britain's success too lies, quite simply, in the fact that after 1757, by its conquest of Bengal, the East India Company had gained control of India's richest province. This gave it the resources to dominate the other players in the continuing contests among India's regional states. With a larger revenue base, the Company could field a larger army than its Indian rivals, and organize a more efficient state structure. As a result, even though the British state in Bengal was forged, in large part, from the same elements of 'military fiscalism' as other states throughout the subcontinent, it could over time subdue them all one by one.